

Recovering Informative Estimates in Failed Placebo-Controlled List Experiments Supplementary Materials

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July 30, 2026

Table of contents

A. Frequency of placebo controlled list experiments	3
B. Descriptive statistics	4
C. Additional results	7
D. Questionnaire	12
Spanish wording of sensitive items and placebo	12
Spanish original	12

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English translation	20
References	27

A. Frequency of placebo controlled list experiments

The main text mentions how placebo-controlled list experiments are used infrequently despite their promise to reduce bias from non-strategic errors in a cost-efficient manner. Here we present some data to support that claim based on an AI-assisted snowball search using Claude Sonnet 4.6 through the Claude Code terminal interface. The entire process, including human validation, started on April 29, 2026 and ended on May 22, 2026. All AI-generated output was manually checked by the researchers and we take full responsibility for any mistakes.

We started by merging two seed lists of previously conducted list experiments (Imai 2011; Blair et al. 2020). The resulting list contains both published and unpublished work using list experiments in political science and adjacent journals. We updated the entries for manuscripts that were coded as unpublished but became published after the original lists were created. We then conducted forward searches within the same 48 journals already included in the list for new entries that include list experiments, focusing on the 2020-2025 range since the entries in the original lists go up to 2019.

At this point, we noticed that the list omitted Rimbau and Ostwald (2020) and Agerberg and Tannenberg (2021), two recent papers that make an explicit case for placebo-control design variants. We included these in the list and augmented it with the list of published articles and publicly available unpublished manuscripts that directly cited them up to the year 2026.

After filtering out false positives manually (e.g. studies that mentions list experiments but do not report the results of one), we ended up with a list of 120 unique manuscripts. We then automatically coded and manually reviewed whether each entry uses a placebo item or a placebo control design. The distinction is important because some studies mention using a placebo item for validation but do not resort to the specific placebo-controlled design discussed in the main text (e.g. Ahlquist et al. 2014). Claude had the tendency to conflate both, so every entry after 2014 was checked manually.

The first mention of placebo items dates back to Ahlquist et al. (2014), whereas Riambau and Ostwald (2020) is the first published entry that explicitly suggests a placebo-controlled design (although their application does not use such a design). Out of the 81 entries since 2014, ten use a placebo item of some sort ($\approx 12.4\%$), while only five of them use a placebo-controlled design ($\approx 6.17\%$), with the oldest entries starting in the year 2021.

This is far from being a comprehensive or representative list, but it is sufficient to sustain the claim that placebo-controlled designs have not become common practice in political science and adjacent fields. We do not have enough information to determine the reason for the infrequent use, but this aligns with previous work showing that empirical work using list experiments rarely deviates from the conventional single list design (Blair et al. 2020).

B. Descriptive statistics

- Table B1 shows descriptive statistics on available demographic variables.
- Figure B1 shows the distribution of responses to both list A and B, divided by treatment (includes sensitive item) and control group (placebo item). Overall, the distribution of responses and associated χ^2 tests do not show evidence of treatment responses deflating in large magnitude. Across panels, we do not have enough evidence against the null hypothesis of treatment and control responses being drawn from different distributions. The exception is the third panel on the right ($p = 0.039$). However, the Bonferroni-corrected threshold for statistical significance at conventional levels in this case is $0.05/8 \approx 0.006$ since we are performing multiple comparisons.

Table B1: Sample characteristics

Variable	N	Mean	SD	Min	Max
Age (years)	2668	41.372	15.192	18	100
<i>Sex</i>					
Female	2668	0.642	0.479	0	1
Male	2668	0.353	0.478	0	1
Other sex	2668	0.005	0.070	0	1
<i>Education</i>					
Primary incomplete	2555	0.023	0.149	0	1
Primary complete	2555	0.069	0.254	0	1
Secondary incomplete	2555	0.291	0.454	0	1
Secondary complete	2555	0.190	0.392	0	1
Tertiary incomplete	2555	0.264	0.441	0	1
Tertiary complete	2555	0.163	0.370	0	1
<i>Race</i>					
White	2525	0.741	0.438	0	1
Afro-descendant	2525	0.104	0.306	0	1
Indigenous	2525	0.069	0.253	0	1
Other race	2525	0.086	0.280	0	1
<i>Employment</i>					
Worked last week	2545	0.560	0.496	0	1
<i>Income</i>					
Not enough, faces great difficulties	2519	0.112	0.316	0	1
Not enough, faces some difficulty	2519	0.353	0.478	0	1
Enough to make ends meet	2519	0.424	0.494	0	1
Enough to save	2519	0.110	0.313	0	1

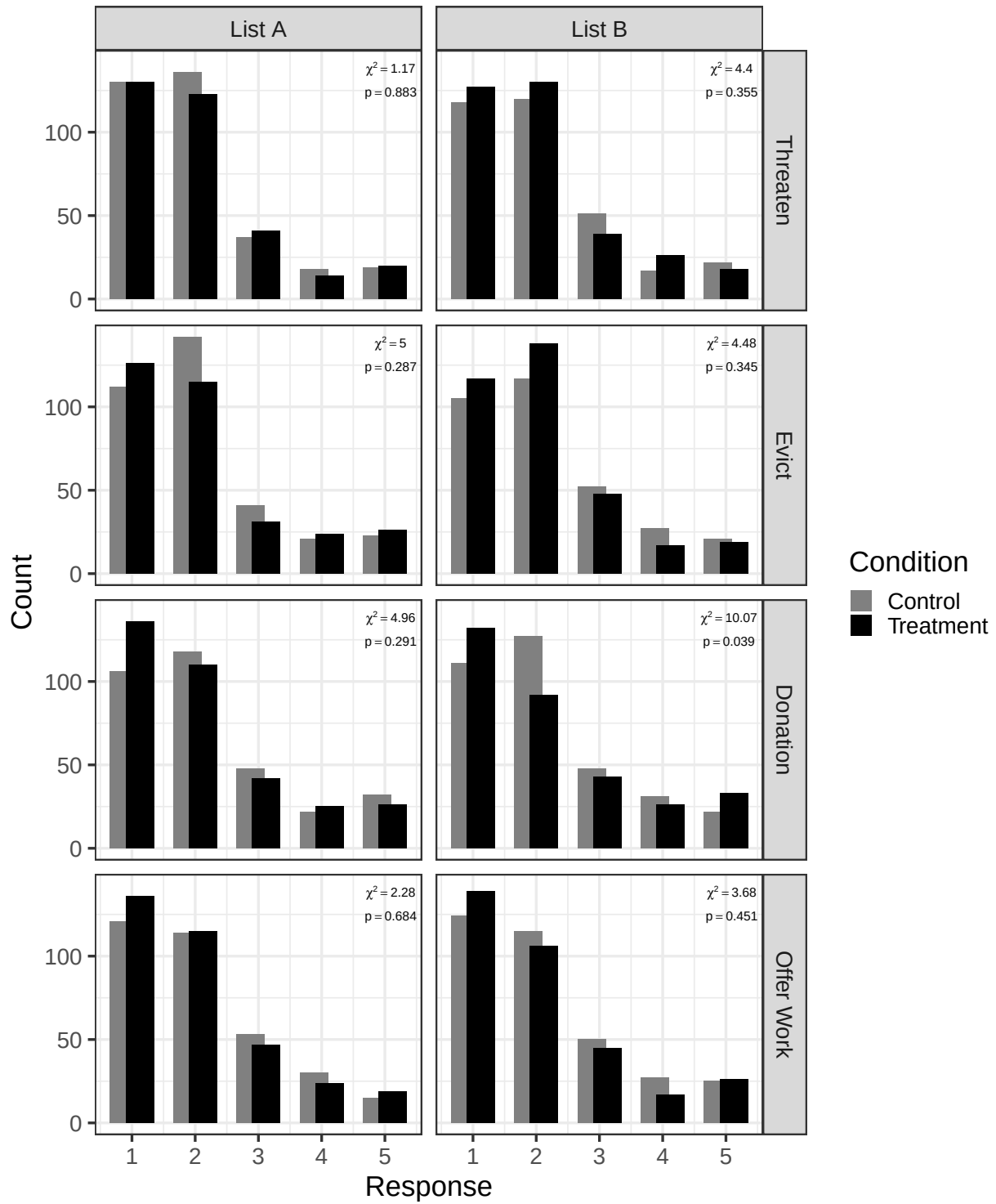


Figure B1: Distribution on responses to list experiment questions with χ^2 tests

C. Additional results

- Table C1 shows the interaction coefficient between failing the mock vignette attention check and the sensitive item placement indicator. This can be interpreted as an estimate on whether failing the attention check alters treatment effects.
- Table C2 shows the interaction coefficient between the raw mock vignette responses and the sensitive item placement indicator.
- Table C3 shows the interaction coefficient between the numerical distance from the correct answer in the mock vignette recall question and the sensitive item placement indicator
- Table C4 shows OLS regression estimates for the relationship between the mock vignette responses and total time spent on list experiment questions (adding List A and B)

Table C1: Effects do not vary by failed mock vignette attention check

Item	Estimate	SE	p-value
<i>List A</i>			
Threatening neighbors	0.015	0.346	0.96495
Evicting neighbors	0.132	0.268	0.6239
Making donations	-0.253	0.233	0.28112
Offering work	0.335	0.196	0.091
<i>List B</i>			
Threatening neighbors	-0.015	0.475	0.97478
Evicting neighbors	0.402	0.411	0.32851
Making donations	-0.615	0.402	0.12648
Offering work	-0.244	0.325	0.45411
<i>Double</i>			
Threatening neighbors	0.128	0.456	0.77951
Evicting neighbors	-0.192	0.434	0.65909
Making donations	0.140	0.454	0.75733
Offering work	0.935	0.335	0.00539

Note: Estimates represent the regression coefficient for the interaction between a binary indicator denoting whether the respondent failed the attention check and the sensitive item placement indicator. Drawn from OLS regression models with block fixed effects and HC2 robust standard errors (for List A and) and clustered standard errors by respondent (for the Double list experiment).

Table C2: Effects do not vary by raw mock vignette response

Item	Estimate	SE	p-value
<i>List A</i>			
Threatening neighbors	-0.005	0.046	0.9137
Evicting neighbors	-0.002	0.039	0.9515
Making donations	0.005	0.037	0.8991
Offering work	-0.033	0.034	0.3424
<i>List B</i>			
Threatening neighbors	-0.043	0.067	0.517
Evicting neighbors	0.069	0.065	0.2858
Making donations	-0.108	0.068	0.1162
Offering work	-0.097	0.057	0.0879
<i>Double</i>			
Threatening neighbors	0.036	0.066	0.5869
Evicting neighbors	-0.073	0.064	0.2507
Making donations	0.122	0.071	0.0844
Offering work	0.035	0.059	0.558

Note: Estimates represent the regression coefficient for the interaction between the raw mock vignette response and the sensitive item placement indicator. Drawn from OLS regression models with block fixed effects and HC2 robust standard errors (for List A and List B) and clustered standard errors by respondent (for the Double list experiment).

Table C3: Effects do not vary by distance from correct answer on recalling the number of items on mock vignette

Item	Estimate	SE	p-value
<i>List A</i>			
Threatening neighbors	0.014	0.044	0.746
Evicting neighbors	0.004	0.039	0.924
Making donations	-0.020	0.037	0.595
Offering work	-0.030	0.041	0.465
<i>List B</i>			
Threatening neighbors	0.096	0.075	0.199
Evicting neighbors	-0.058	0.076	0.445
Making donations	0.049	0.079	0.533
Offering work	-0.059	0.073	0.424
<i>Double</i>			
Threatening neighbors	-0.068	0.075	0.366
Evicting neighbors	0.056	0.068	0.414
Making donations	-0.087	0.080	0.278
Offering work	-0.007	0.076	0.932

Note: Estimates represent the regression coefficient for the interaction between the distance from the correct answer on recalling the number of items on the mock vignette and the sensitive item placement indicator. Drawn from OLS regression models with block fixed effects and HC2 robust standard errors (for List A and List B) and clustered standard errors by respondent (for the Double list experiment).

Table C4: Mock vignette responses and time spent on list experiment questions

	Attention check	Raw response
Intercept	72.096*	71.169*
	(0.787)	(1.446)
Failed attention check	0.571	
	(2.315)	
Raw response		0.369
		(0.418)
Num.Obs.	2668	2668
R2	0.000	0.000

* $p < 0.05$

Note: OLS regression models with HC2 robust standard errors. Outcome is total time spent on both list experiment questions (in seconds).

D. Questionnaire

Spanish wording of sensitive items and placebo

Sensitive items

- Vi a miembros de bandas amenazar a vecinos
- Vi a miembros de banda sacar a vecinos de sus casas
- Vi a miembros de bandas hacer donaciones en mi barrio
- Vi a miembros de bandas ofrecer trabajo a personas en mi barrio

Placebo

- No tomé mate

Spanish original

1. ¿Qué edad tiene?

- [0-100 slider]

2. ¿En qué Barrio de Montevideo vive?

- [Drop down menu. Filtered out if R does not live in Montevideo]

3. ¿Cuál es su género?

- Femenino
- Masculino
- Otro

4. Cree tener ascendencia...

- Blanca
- Afro o negra
- Indígena

- Otro

5. ¿Qué servicios del Estado utiliza habitualmente?

[MULTIPLE CHOICE]

- Centros CAIF
- Tarjeta del MIDES
- Centros de enseñanza pública
- Centros de salud pública
- Centros de deporte públicos
- Centros culturales o bibliotecas públicas
- Programas de empleo
- Apoyo del Estado para el supergas o la luz
- Asignaciones familiares
- Otro
- Ninguno

6. Las siguientes preguntas intentan comprender la relación entre actitudes y comportamientos. Por favor, lea cada lista con atención e indique cuántos elementos lo describen a usted. **Sólo queremos saber cuántos, no cuáles.**

- He estado en Estados Unidos
- Me considero un aficionado a los deportes
- Tengo un hermano
- Tengo más de una hermana
- He leído el libro “Cien Años de Soledad”
- Voté por correo en las últimas elecciones nacionales

7. Según recuerda, ¿cuántos elementos vio en la lista anterior?

[List 1-8]

[LISTS A AND B PRESENTED IN RANDOM ORDER]

8. [LIST A] Nos interesa conocer sus experiencias en el barrio donde vive. Por favor, díganos cuántas de estas cosas le pasaron en su barrio **en los últimos seis meses.**

Sólo queremos saber cuántas, no cuáles.

- Vi personas haciendo deporte en mi barrio
- Visité amigos los fines de semana
- Participé en actividades organizadas por grupos feministas
- Participé en ceremonias religiosas en mi barrio
- [RANDOMLY ASSIGNED SENSITIVE ITEM OR PLACEBO]

9. [LIST B] Nos interesa conocer sus experiencias en el barrio donde vive. Por favor, díganos cuántas de estas cosas le pasaron en su barrio **en los últimos seis meses.**

Sólo queremos saber cuántas, no cuáles.

- Vi personas jugando al fútbol los fines de semana
- Conversé con mis amigos frecuentemente
- Participé en actividades organizadas por grupos de diversidad sexual
- Participé en actividades solidarias organizadas por la iglesia en mi barrio
- [RANDOMLY ASSIGNED SENSITIVE ITEM OR PLACEBO]

10. [DIRECT QUESTIONS] Durante los últimos meses, en su barrio, vio a bandas...

[YES/NO GRID. ITEMS SHUFFLED]

- Ofrecer trabajo a vecinos
- Hacer donaciones en el barrio
- Amenazar a vecinos
- Desalojar a vecinos de sus casas
- Extorsionar a vecinos
- Extorsionar a negocios

- Pagar la luz o el teléfono a vecinos
11. Marque el máximo nivel educativo que ha alcanzado
- Primaria incompleta
 - Primaria completa
 - Secundaria incompleta
 - Secundaria completa
 - Terciaria incompleta
 - Terciaria completa
12. Ahora le vamos a preguntar por su situación laboral. ¿La semana pasada trabajó a cambio de un pago por lo menos una hora?
- Sí
 - No
13. [DISPLAY IF YES TO 12] ¿Aporta a alguna caja de jubilaciones por este trabajo?
- Sí
 - No
14. El total del ingreso de su hogar:
- Le alcanza bien y puede ahorrar
 - Le alcanza justo, no tiene grandes dificultades
 - No le alcanza, tiene dificultades
 - No le alcanza, tiene grandes dificultades
15. En los últimos 12 meses, el ingreso de su hogar:
- Aumentó
 - Permaneció igual
 - Disminuyó

16. En los últimos doce meses, ¿usted ha recibido ayuda económica on es especie de...
(puede marcar más de una)

- Algún programa del gobierno?
- Un familiar que vive en su vivienda?
- Un familiar que vive en otra vivienda?
- Otro tipo de ayuda
- No ha recibido ayuda

17. Ahora le haremos algunas preguntas sobre su relación con sus vecinos. Por favor, marque la respuesta que corresponda junto a cada pregunta.

[DISCRETE GRID WITH CHOICES: NADA, POCO, ALGO, MUCHO]

- ¿Con qué frecuencia visita o recibe visitas de vecinos de su barrio?
- ¿Con qué frecuencia habla personalmente o por teléfono con los vecinos de su barrio?
- ¿Con qué frecuencia usted y sus vecinos intercambian favores como cuidar o jugar con sus hijos, prestarse cosas o alimentos, vigilar su casa o auto, etc.?
- En los últimos 12 meses, ¿realizó acciones conjuntas con sus vecinos para atender algún problema de su barrio?
- ¿Cuánto confía en sus vecinos?

18. Pensando en el lugar donde usted vive, en una escala del 1 al 7, donde 1 es nada probable y 7 es muy probable, ¿cuál cree que es la probabilidad de...?

- Ser amenazado
- Ser asaltado
- Ser herido con un arma
- Escuchar tiroteos
- Ser asesinado

19. Diría usted que, durante los últimos 12 meses, ¿la seguridad pública en su barrio...?

- Ha mejorado mucho
- Ha mejorado poco
- Ha permanecido igual
- Ha empeorado poco
- Ha empeorado mucho

20. ¿Hasta que punto diría que hay presencia de bandas en su barrio?

- Mucho
- Algo
- Poco
- Nada

21. Si pasara alguna de las siguientes situaciones en su barrio, ¿qué tan probable es que usted acuda a la policía?

[SLIDER GRID FROM 1: NADA PROBABLE TO 7: MUY PROBABLE]

- Cuando hay ruidos molestos
- Cuando hay algún robo de una bicicleta o moto
- Si un vecino recibe amenazas
- Cuando alguien se niega a pagar una deuda
- Cuando hay una pelea entre jóvenes en la calle
- Si un vecino es golpeado en la calle
- Si necesita pedir dinero prestado [DISPLAY IF ANSWER TO 20 $\neq$ NADA]
- Si necesita pedir trabajo [DISPLAY IF ANSWER TO 20 $\neq$ NADA]

22. En una escala de 1 a 7, donde 1 es nada y 7 es mucho, cuando se trata de resolver problemas en su barrio, ¿cuánto confía en...?

- El Poder Judicial
- La policía

- La Guardia Republicana
 - El municipio
 - Los concejales vecinales
 - Las bandas [DISPLAY IF ANSWER TO 20 $\neq$ NADA]
23. En una escala de 1 a 7, donde 1 es muy en desacuerdo y 7 es muy de acuerdo, ¿qué tan de acuerdo está con las siguientes afirmaciones?
- La diferencia de ingresos entre los ricos y los pobres es demasiado grande
 - Puede que la democracia tenga problemas, pero es mejor que cualquier otra forma de gobierno
 - El Estado, más que el sector privado, debería ser el principal responsable de los servicios públicos como agua y electricidad
 - El Estado debería tomar medidas para reducir las diferencias entre ricos y pobres
24. ¿A qué partido votó en las elecciones de octubre de 2019?
- Partido Nacional
 - Partido Colorado
 - Frente Amplio
 - Unidad Popular
 - Partido de la Gente
 - Cabildo Abierto
 - Partido Independiente
 - Otro
 - No votó
 - Votó en blanco o anulado
25. Ahora, le haremos unas preguntas sobre sus relaciones y contactos sociales. ¿Cuántas personas conoce y que a su vez lo conoced a usted, con quien ha interactuado en el último año ya sea en persona, por teléfono, o por algún otro medio...?

[GRID SCALE 0-10 OR MORE. ITEM ORDER SHUFFLED]

- Que vivan en Las Piedras
- Que sean hombres entre 25 y 29 años
- Que sean policías
- Que estén en la universidad
- Que hayan tenido un hijo en el último año
- Que hayan fallecido en el último año
- Que se hayan casado en el último año
- Que sean mujeres entre 45 y 49 años

26. Ahora, le haremos otras preguntas también sobre sus relaciones y contactos sociales.

¿Cuántas personas conoce y que a su vez lo conoced a usted, con quien ha interactuado en el último año ya sea en persona, por teléfono, o por algún otro medio...?

[GRID SCALE 0-10 OR MORE. ITEM ORDER SHUFFLED]

- Que son empleados públicos
- Que tienen la tarjeta del MIDES
- Que militan en un partido político
- Cuyos hijos asistan a una escuela pública
- Que no hayan votado en las últimas elecciones nacionales
- [LIST EXPERIMENT SENSITIVE ITEM]
- Que estén actualmente en la cárcel
- Que hayan perdido su trabajo en el último año

27. ¿Le gustaría participar en un sorteo por un celular smartphone? Sus respuestas a esta encuesta siguen siendo anónimas.

- Sí
- No

English translation

1. How old are you?

- [0-100 slider]

2. Which neighborhood in Montevideo do you live in?

- [Drop down menu. Filtered out if R does not live in Montevideo]

3. What is your gender?

- Female
- Male
- Other

4. What do you consider your ancestry to be?

- White
- Afro or Black
- Indigenous
- Other

5. Which government services do you typically use?

[MULTIPLE CHOICE]

- CAIF Centers (Early-childhood care and family support)
- MIDES card (Food stamps/EBT card)
- Public schools
- Public health centers
- Public recreation centers
- Cultural centers or public libraries
- Employment programs
- State support for cooking gas or electricity bills

- Family allowances
- Other
- None

6. The following questions try to understand the relationship between attitudes and behaviors. Please read each list carefully and indicate how many of the items describe you. **We only want to know how many, not which ones.**

- I have been to the United States
- I consider myself a sports fan
- I have a brother
- I have more than one sister
- I have read the book “One Hundred Years of Solitude”
- I voted by mail in the last national election

7. To the best of your recollection, how many items were in the previous list?

[List 1-8]

[LISTS A AND B PRESENTED IN RANDOM ORDER]

8. [LIST A] We are interested in learning about your experiences in the neighborhood where you live. Please tell us how many of these things happened to you in your neighborhood **in the last six months. We only want to know how many, not which ones.**

- I saw people doing sports in my neighborhood
- I visited friends on weekends
- I participated in activities organized by feminist groups
- I participated in religious ceremonies in my neighborhood
- [RANDOMLY ASSIGNED SENSITIVE ITEM OR PLACEBO]

9. [LIST B] We are interested in learning about your experiences in the neighborhood

where you live. Please tell us how many of these things happened to you in your neighborhood **in the last six months. We only want to know how many, not which ones.**

- I saw people playing soccer on weekends
- I talked with my friends frequently
- I participated in activities organized by LGBTQ groups
- I participated in charitable activities organized by the church in my neighborhood
- [RANDOMLY ASSIGNED SENSITIVE ITEM OR PLACEBO]

10. [DIRECT QUESTIONS] During the last few months, in your neighborhood, did you see gangs...

[YES/NO GRID. ITEMS SHUFFLED]

- Offer work to neighbors
- Make donations in the neighborhood
- Threaten neighbors
- Evict neighbors from their homes
- Extort neighbors
- Extort businesses
- Pay for neighbors' electricity or phone bills

11. Mark the highest level of education you have completed

- Primary incomplete
- Primary complete
- Secondary incomplete
- Secondary complete
- Tertiary incomplete
- Tertiary complete

12. Now we will ask about your employment situation. Last week, did you work for pay for at least one hour?
- Yes
 - No
13. [DISPLAY IF YES TO 12] Did you contribute to a pension fund through this job?
- Yes
 - No
14. Your total household income:
- Is enough and you can save
 - Is just enough, no major difficulties
 - Is not enough, you face difficulties
 - Is not enough, you face great difficulties
15. In the last 12 months, your household income:
- Increased
 - Stayed the same
 - Decreased
16. In the last twelve months, have you received economic assistance or assistance in kind from... (you may select more than one)
- Some government program?
 - A relative who lives in your household?
 - A relative who lives in another household?
 - Other type of assistance
 - Have not received assistance
17. Now we will ask some questions about your relationship with your neighbors. Please

mark the answer that corresponds to each question.

[DISCRETE GRID WITH CHOICES: NOTHING, LITTLE, SOME, A LOT]

- How often do you visit or receive visits from neighbors in your area?
 - How often do you speak in person or by phone with your neighbors?
 - How often do you and your neighbors exchange favors such as watching or playing with each other's children, lending things or food, watching each other's house or car, etc.?
 - In the last 12 months, did you take joint action with your neighbors to address a problem in your neighborhood?
 - How much do you trust your neighbors?
18. Thinking about the place where you live, on a scale from 1 to 7, where 1 is not at all likely and 7 is very likely, how likely do you think it is that...?
- You will be threatened
 - You will be robbed
 - You will be injured with a weapon
 - You will hear gunshots
 - You will be killed
19. Would you say that, over the last 12 months, public safety in your neighborhood...?
- Has improved a lot
 - Has improved a little
 - Has stayed the same
 - Has gotten a little worse
 - Has gotten a lot worse
20. To what extent would you say there is gang presence in your neighborhood?
- A lot
 - Some

- Little
- None

21. If any of the following situations happened in your neighborhood, how likely is it that you would go to the police?

[SLIDER GRID FROM 1: NOT AT ALL LIKELY TO 7: VERY LIKELY]

- When there is disturbing noise
- When bike or motorcycle gets stolen
- If a neighbor receives threats
- When someone refuses to pay a debt
- When there is a fight between young people in the street
- If a neighbor gets beaten in the street
- If you need to borrow money [DISPLAY IF ANSWER TO 20 $\neq$ NONE]
- If you need help finding work [DISPLAY IF ANSWER TO 20 $\neq$ NONE]

22. On a scale from 1 to 7, where 1 is none and 7 is a lot, when it comes to solving problems in your neighborhood, how much do you trust...?

- The Judiciary
- The police
- The *Guardia Republicana* (Similar US National Guard but for domestic security only)
- The municipal government
- Neighborhood council members
- Gangs [DISPLAY IF ANSWER TO 20 $\neq$ NONE]

23. On a scale of 1 to 7, where 1 is strongly disagree and 7 is strongly agree, how much do you agree with the following statements?

- The income gap between the rich and the poor is too large
- Democracy may have problems, but it is better than any other form of government

- The State, rather than the private sector, should be primarily responsible for public services such as water and electricity
- The State should take measures to reduce the gap between rich and poor

24. Which party did you vote for in the October 2019 elections?

- Partido Nacional
- Partido Colorado
- Frente Amplio
- Unidad Popular
- Partido de la Gente
- Cabildo Abierto
- Partido Independiente
- Other
- Did not vote
- Voted blank or invalid

25. Now, we will ask you some questions about your relationships and social contacts. How many people do you know, and who in turn know you, with whom you have interacted in the last year either in person, by phone, or through some other means...?

[GRID SCALE 0-10 OR MORE. ITEM ORDER SHUFFLED]

- Who live in Las Piedras
- Who are men between 25 and 29 years old
- Who are police officers
- Who are in college
- Who have had a child in the last year
- Who have passed away in the last year
- Who have gotten married in the last year
- Who are women between 45 and 49 years old

26. Now, we will ask you other questions also about your relationships and social contacts.

How many people do you know, and who in turn know you, with whom you have interacted in the last year either in person, by phone, or through some other means...?

[GRID SCALE 0-10 OR MORE. ITEM ORDER SHUFFLED]

- Who are public employees
- Who have the MIDES card
- Who are registered members of a political party
- Whose children attend public school
- Who did not vote in the last national election
- [LIST EXPERIMENT SENSITIVE ITEM]
- Who are currently in prison
- Who have lost their job in the last year

27. Would you like to participate in a raffle for a smartphone? Your responses to this survey remain anonymous.

- Yes
- No

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